# Lesson 29: Past Tenses in Writing

*English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 3: Verb Tenses and Narration · The Human Lifespan*

*Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 12 Expressing Meaning in Past Tenses; Appendix D Irregular Verbs.*

## In this lesson

You will learn the forms and meanings of three past tenses (simple past, past progressive and past perfect) and check irregular forms in Appendix D. You will take a pretest about the Great Fire of London (do Practice 1 before you read the rules), complete a history and a story, and correct paragraphs with past-tense errors. Clear past tenses are essential when you report research, describe historical events or tell a story in academic writing.

## Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Form the simple past with regular and irregular verbs, "did" + base verb and "used to" + base verb.
- Use the past progressive for actions in progress at a past time, interrupted by a short action, or at the same time as another action.
- Use the past perfect for an action that was completed before another past action.
- Punctuate sentences with "when" and "while" clauses.
- Find and correct past-tense errors in a paragraph.

## Key language

| Word or phrase | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| simple past | base verb + -ed (regular) or an irregular form (went, saw) | It destroyed a big part of London. |
| past progressive (pro·GRES·sive) | was/were + verb-ing | At 9 am on a Monday last December, I was driving to college. |
| past perfect | had + past participle (PAR·ti·ci·ple: the third form, e.g. taken, gone) | Many of them had never had an online course before. |
| irregular verb (ir·REG·u·lar) | a verb whose past forms do not end in -ed | go, went, gone |
| used to + base verb | a past habit or regular activity that is not true now | My mother used to make sure that the stove was off. |
| terror (TER·ror) | noun: intense fear | People in London used to talk about this fire in great terror. |
| reminisce (rem·i·NISCE) | verb: remember past experiences or events | reminisce about your life together |

| Word or phrase | Meaning | Example |
|---|---|---|
| celebrity (ce·LEB·ri·ty) | noun: a famous person | Write about a celebrity. |

## Rules and explanations

### Simple past

1. With was/were as the main verb, use no "do" verb; with a "do" verb, use no was/were. Not "It was occurred in 1666" but "It occurred in 1666"; not "The rats were bring dirt" but "The rats brought dirt". Every sentence needs a verb: not "The Great Fire of London a major disaster" but "The Great Fire of London was a major disaster."
2. Regular "do" verbs add -ed: "It destroyed a big part of London."
3. After "did" in questions and negatives, use the base form: "How long did it last? It lasted almost five days." "Did it kill many people? No, it did not kill too many people."
4. "Used to + base verb" is common for past regular activities: "People in London used to talk about this fire in great terror."

(The book's review box says that was and were are the only two "do" verbs in the simple past. This is a slip: they are the two "be" verbs.)

- **Meaning 1: started and completed at a specific time in the past.** Yesterday, last night, two days ago, in 2000. "The Great Chicago Fire occurred on October 8th through October 10th in 1871."
- **Meaning 2: past routines, past habits, past situations.** Always, usually, often, sometimes, never, every day, once a week, on Tuesdays. "My parents did not allow my younger sister to be near the flame, but they let me because I was old enough."

### Past progressive: was/were + verb-ing (no non-action verbs)

- **Meaning 1: in progress at a specific time in the past.** At this time yesterday, at 9 am this morning, at that moment, at that time. "It was snowing at that moment."
- **Meaning 2: a long action in progress when a short action happened.** "When" + simple past for the shorter action; "while" + past progressive for the longer action. "I was driving to our college when we heard on the radio that there was an accident just ahead of us." / "While I was driving, we heard on the radio that there was an accident just ahead of us."
- **Meaning 3: two actions in progress at the same time.** While. "I was driving while Angela was drinking coffee."
- **Punctuation:** a sentence with a "when" or "while" clause is a complex sentence. If the "when/while" clause (a dependent clause: it cannot stand alone as a sentence) comes first, put a comma after it: "When we heard the news, Angela was drinking ...". If the main (independent) clause comes first, use no comma: "I was driving while Angela was drinking coffee."
- Non-action verbs (Lesson 5: know, like, love, need, have ...) are not used in the past progressive.

### Past perfect: had + past participle

- **Meaning: an action or situation that had completed or repeated before another past action or situation.** By then, by that time, by + a past time, by + a past time clause, when, until, as soon as, before, after.
- "When the semester started in January 2021, many college students had already taken online classes for at least one semester."
- "Had all the professors taught virtually before the Covid lockdown in March 2020? No, most of them had not."

### Irregular verbs (Appendix D)

Some verbs from this unit's exercises (base form, simple past, past participle):

| Base | Past | Participle | Base | Past | Participle |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| become | became | become | go | went | gone |
| begin | began | begun | have | had | had |
| bring | brought | brought | lead | led | led |
| buy | bought | bought | leave | left | left |
| catch | caught | caught | ride | rode | ridden |
| find | found | found | say | said | said |
| forget | forgot | forgotten | think | thought | thought |
| get | got | got (American English also: gotten) | give | gave | given |

Three mistakes in the printed chart: hear, heard, **heard** (not "head"); show, **showed**, shown (not "show"); wake, woke, **woken** (not "waken").

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Arabic uses one form ("was" + a present verb) for both a past habit and an action in progress. English separates them: a past habit is simple past or "used to" ("We went to the beach every Sunday"); an action in progress is was/were + -ing ("We were taking the quiz").

## Practice

**1. Pretest (Section I): the Great Fire of London.** If the verb(s) in bold are correct, choose "correct". If not, choose one of the other answers.

1. There **was** lots of rats in London in the 17th century. a) correct b) had c) were
2. The rats **brought** dirt and disease to the people. As a result, many people in London got sick, and thousands **were died**. a) bring, were die b) brought, died c) correct
3. Then something unexpected **happened**. a) correct b) happening c) was happened

4. On September 2, 1666, while John Farynor, the King's baker, **was sleeping** in a room above his baker's shop, a man discovered that some wood **caught** fire and the kitchen was beginning to burn. He immediately woke up Mr. Farynor. a) correct b) slept, caught c) was sleeping, had caught
5. A strong wind **blowing** then, and the fire quickly **moved** through the city. It became out of control. a) correct b) was blowing, move c) was blowing, moved
6. King Charles **had led** the fight and **worked** for thirty hours without sleep. a) correct b) lead, worked c) led, worked
7. On September 5, the fire **was** finally under control. a) correct b) is c) were
8. The Great Fire of London **had** several important results. a) correct b) has c) was have
9. One good result **was** that it finally **stopped** the disease caused by the rats. a) correct b) is, stopped c) was, stopping
10. The fire **was** one of the most well-known disasters in the history of London, but it **did** something positive as well. a) correct b) is, did c) was, done

**2. Book Exercise 1: "The Great Chicago Fire".** In your lesson material, fill in the blanks with the correct simple past verbs (not including the example, "started"). The blanks, in order: (1) find, (2) believe, (3) be, (4) be, (5) can, (6) have, (7) act, (8) receive, (9) go, (10) cause.

**3. Book Exercise 2: "A Man and His Donkeys".** In your lesson material, fill in the blanks with the simple past or past progressive (not including the example, "happened"). The blanks, in order: (1) walk, (2) become, (3) decide, (4) continue, (5) ride, (6) stop, (7) count, (8) be, (9) get, (10) search, (11) wait, (12) give, (13) return, (14) count, (15) think, (16) return, (17) look, (18) be, (19) tell, (20) start, (21) have, (22) say.

**4. Book Exercise 3.** Write answers with the past perfect. (If you have not lived in the United States, answer about another country you have visited, or about the time before you started university.)

1. When you began this semester, how many English classes had you taken?
2. Before you arrived in the United States, had you ever spoken on the phone in English?
3. Before you came to the United States, what food had you never tasted?
4. Before you left for the United States, how many times had you been to the consulate in order to get your visa?

**5. Book Exercise 4: "A Positive Attitude".** In your lesson material, find and correct ten more errors in the underlined verbs (not including the example, "are (were)"). If the underlining does not show in your copy, check every verb.

**6. Book Exercise 6: "Childhood Memories".** In your lesson material, find fourteen more errors in the use of verb tenses and correct them (not including the example, "am having (have)").

More practice: lesson material, Exercise 5 ("A Quiz and a Joke"). Your tutor can check it.

## Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me what I was doing at 9 am yesterday, at 8 pm last Friday and at this time last year. Correct my past progressive."

- "Let me retell 'A Man and His Donkeys' in my own words. Check my simple past, past progressive and irregular verbs."
- "Ask me the four past perfect questions from Exercise 3, then ask follow-up questions. Correct my tenses."
- "Here is my paragraph: [paste]. Underline every past verb and tell me if the tense matches my meaning and my time words."

## Read aloud

Mark the -ed ending: /ɪd/ after t and d sounds, /t/ after other voiceless sounds, /d/ after voiced sounds.

1. The fire started /ɪd/ at about 8:30 pm on October 8, 1871.
2. The Fire Department acted /ɪd/ quickly, but the firefighters received /d/ the wrong information.
3. While he was riding, he stopped /t/ to count his donkeys.
4. After twenty minutes, the man gave up, returned /d/ to his donkeys, and counted /ɪd/ them again.

## Writing task

**Book Exercise 7.** Choose one topic and write a paragraph of about 150-200 words. Use appropriate past tenses.

- Write a paragraph about your teenage years. What were you like? What did you like to do then? Was there anything that you had experienced in your early childhood to cause you to think or behave the way you did as a teenager?
- Write a letter to your spouse, child(ren), or parent(s) and reminisce about your life together.
- Write about a celebrity. What do you know about his or her life and career?

Self-editing checklist:

- I never used was/were together with a "do" verb ("was occurred", "were die").
- After "did" and "didn't" I used the base form ("did not leave").
- I checked every irregular verb in Appendix D.
- I used was/were + -ing only for actions in progress, never with non-action verbs.
- I used had + past participle for an action before another past action.
- A "when" or "while" clause at the start of a sentence has a comma after it.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

## Watch online

- The Great Fire of London on Wikipedia, the source of the pretest (the book's link): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Great_Fire_of_London
- The Great Chicago Fire on Wikipedia, the source of Exercise 1 (the book's link): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Great_Chicago_Fire

## Answer key

**1.** (book): 1. c) were 2. b) brought, died 3. a) correct 4. c) was sleeping, had caught 5. c) was blowing, moved 6. c) led, worked 7. a) correct 8. a) correct 9. a) correct 10. a) correct. (In item 5, "It became out of control" is the book's wording; "It got out of control" is more natural.)

**2.** (book) 1. found 2. believed 3. was 4. was 5. could 6. had 7. acted 8. received 9. went 10. caused

**3.** (book) 1. was walking 2. became 3. decided 4. continued 5. was riding 6. stopped 7. counted 8. was 9. got 10. was searching 11. were waiting 12. gave 13. returned 14. counted 15. thought 16. returned 17. was looking 18. was 19. told 20. started / had started 21. had 22. said

**4.** (example answers) 1. When I began this semester, I had taken three English classes. 2. Yes, I had. I had spoken on the phone in English a few times. / No, I had never spoken on the phone in English. 3. I had never tasted pumpkin pie. 4. I had been to the consulate twice.

**5.** The story is in the past until "Now"; after "Now" it is in the present.

1. I have never studied English before → I had never studied (before I came)
2. so I am very confused → I was
3. As time goes by → As time went by
4. I force myself → I forced
5. I write a lot → I wrote
6. and I become more confident → I became
7. I had to be patient → I have to be patient (present: "I find that ...")
8. Sometimes, I was frustrated → I am frustrated
9. mistakes helped me learn → mistakes help me learn (a general truth) or have helped me learn
10. I been practicing → I have been practicing

(If you keep 5 and 6 in the present, "each time I used" must become "use"; but the story is still in the past there.)

**6.**

1. my family move → moved
2. we live in Chicago before we moved → we had lived (lived is also possible, because "before" shows the order)
3. when it is time → was
4. my parents were buying our first house → bought (one completed action)
5. did not had to → did not have to
6. I was loving that room → I loved (non-action verb)
7. My mother was liking to sew → liked (non-action verb)
8. We use to pack → used to
9. the food that Mom buy the day before → had bought (or bought)

10. ran, laugh → laughed
11. and play games → played
12. they sitting → sat (or were sitting)
13. and watching us → watched (or, with "were sitting", keep "watching")
14. We often did not left → did not leave

"I will always member" should be "remember": this is a wrong word, not a tense error.

## My notes